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THA 112: Comparative Traditions of World Theatres

Compare performance traditions without ranking them

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Comparison is a skill, not a list. This pack gives you a comparison grid covering space, performer training, text, audience and purpose, then applies it to African festival theatre, Greek theatre, Noh, Commedia dell'arte and contemporary Nigerian stage practice.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Construct a comparison grid for any two performance traditions.
- Describe Greek, Japanese and African traditions using accurate terminology.
- Explain how performer training and audience expectation differ across traditions.
- Avoid evolutionist language that treats one tradition as more advanced.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Compare on dimensions, not vibes

A comparison needs fixed criteria applied to both cases.

- Space: where does performance happen, and who can see whom?
- Text: is there a fixed script, an outline, or an inherited pattern?
- Performer: trained specialist, community member, or both?
- Audience: separated, participating, or paying customers?
- Purpose: civic competition, religious observance, entertainment or social critique?
- Transmission: school, apprenticeship, family lineage or mass media?

> **Do not write 'primitive'**
> Evolutionist language - primitive to sophisticated - is inaccurate and penalised. Say 'participatory' or 'text-centred' and define it.

Three traditions in brief

Know enough detail to support a comparison, not a full history.

- Greek: civic festival of Dionysus, masked actors, chorus, open-air amphitheatre, competition between playwrights.
- Japanese Noh: highly codified movement, masks, chant and a slow tempo; transmission through schools and lineages.
- African festival theatre: community participation, music and dance as structure, flexible performance space.
- Commedia dell'arte: professional troupes, stock characters, improvisation around a scenario, touring economy.
- Nigerian contemporary stage: blends festival elements, literary drama and popular theatre forms.

Writing the comparison answer

Structure carries the marks.

1. Introduce both traditions with dates and contexts.
2. State the criteria you will compare on.
3. Take one criterion at a time and discuss both cases.
4. Give a specific example for each claim.
5. Explain a similarity and a difference in function, not only in appearance.
6. Conclude with what the comparison reveals about theatre as a human practice.

Comparison is a method, not a survey

A comparative answer fails when it becomes two summaries placed next to each other. The fix is to state your criteria before you discuss either tradition, then move criterion by criterion across both cases. Six criteria carry almost every comparison question: the performance space, the status of the text, the training of the performer, the role of the audience, the purpose of the event, and how the tradition is transmitted to the next generation.

Worked properly, a comparison produces a finding rather than a list: for example, that Greek and Noh theatre both formalise performance through masks and inherited conventions, but distribute authority very differently - one through civic competition, the other through hereditary schools. That sentence is an argument; the surrounding detail is its evidence.